

NIGHT 31

Tiffany Wayne



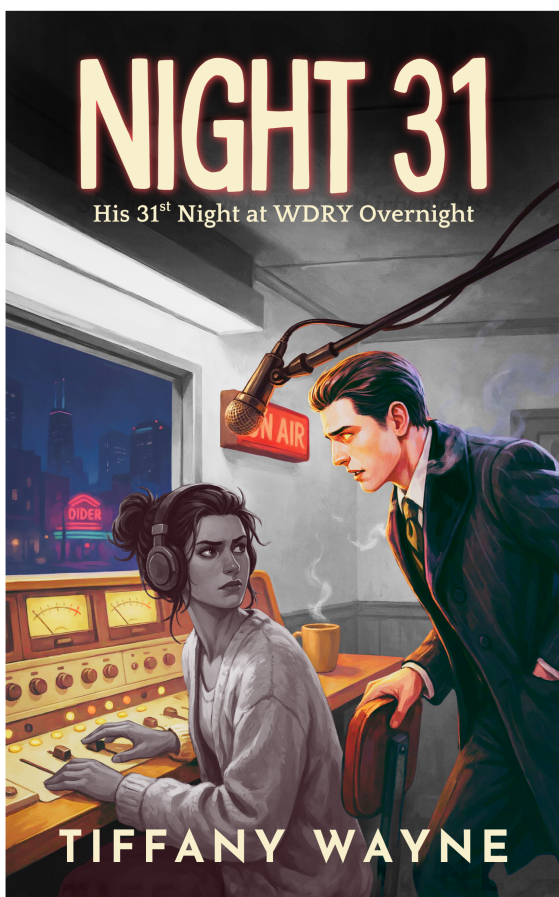
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THIS IS AN EXCLUSIVE BONUS SCENE FROM
"DEAD AIR", ENTIRELY IN DENNIS' POINT OF
VIEW.



There was a new photograph on the wall of the waiting room.

I noticed it at four in the afternoon on the twenty-first of December, which in the waiting room means nothing,

because there are no afternoons there, only the tube humming its one long note and the carpet the color of old nicotine and the girl from somewhere sunny walking past on the strings, forever. But I knew it was four in the afternoon on Milwaukee Avenue, because I had been counting since the check was paid. I had been counting the way a man counts the stops on a train toward home.

The photograph hung where Kimberly's had hung for fourteen months. It was in the same frame. The brass plate beneath it had been changed.

EARNER OF THE MONTH, it said. UZZIMEL ("DENNIS").

The photograph was of me sitting on a curb on Milwaukee Avenue in the slush at 7:21 in the morning, in my good coat, with my face turned up to the sun and my eyes running. I do not know who took it. Hell has never once in five thousand years told me who takes its photographs. It was not flattering. My mouth was open.

I stood in front of it for some time.

"It's so bad," said Kimberly, behind me. "I'm sorry. I tried to get them to use a headshot."

She was standing by my corner with her ring light folded under one arm and her yellow tape measure in her hand. She was not measuring anything. She was winding the tape back into its case, very slowly, the way you would wind up a kite string after the kite has blown away.

"I am told," I said, "that you had chosen sheer linen."

"I had a whole *vision*, Uzzie." She clicked the tape shut. "A feature wall. Soft lighting. It would have been really calming." She looked at the photograph. She looked at me. "One soul. For *pancakes*."

"Diner pancakes."

"Do you know how that makes the rest of us look?" She wasn't smiling. For the first time since the Medicis she wasn't smiling at all, and it made her look younger, and a little lost, like a girl at a bus stop after the last bus. "I did eleven hundred souls last quarter. Paragraph nine. Nobody reads past paragraph four. And you get the wall for a woman who *asked you to breakfast*."

"She did not ask," I said. "She wished. There is a difference. I have been learning it."

Kimberly opened her mouth. Then she closed it, and tucked the ring light more firmly under her arm, and walked away down the long room toward the far door. Halfway there she stopped, the way she always stops.

"She's going to read it tonight," she said, without turning around. "You know that, right? The ad. I listened to the stream. She said it on air at noon. She said, and I'm quoting, *same time tomorrow, Chicago*."

"I know," I said.

I did not know. I had hoped. It is a different thing, and I have been learning that too.

At 2:13 I stood up and straightened my coat.

The cuffs were whole. I checked them anyway. I had been checking them all day, the way you touch a tooth that has stopped aching. I said my name under my breath, the whole of it, *Uzzimel*, all the way to the end, and it stayed. I said the other one too, the one from the name tag, and found I liked the sound of it better.

The hold music came around to the strings. I was humming. Not the girl from somewhere sunny. Something

else: track four of an album by a man in a white turtle-neck, a song about a light left on.

At 2:14 there was a hook behind my ribs.

It was not like the other times. I want to be accurate about this, because I have been summoned perhaps ten thousand times, and every single one of them felt like a hand closing on a collar. This felt like a hand closing on a hand.

"—and a family that picks up the phone," said Margo Dunleavy. "*Uzz-im-elu, ana qaqqari, ina ishati—*"

The booth came up around me: brown carpet, coffee rings, the gaffer-taped boom, the bobblehead under the microphone, already nodding. The foam on the ceiling tile met my head with its soft, familiar insult. *Puff*.

I had missed it terribly.

"Dust to dust," said Margo. "We'll take it from here."

She did not hit a cart. She did not put on a song. She sat with her headphones around her neck and her chin in her hand and looked up at me, and I could hear her, all of her, every station on the dial, and every one was playing the same thing.

"Hi, Dennis," she said.

"Good evening," I said.

I have said *good evening* to kings. I said it to a pope, once, who asked me not to tell anyone which pope. I had never said it to someone who had called me only because she wanted me to come, and it turned out to be an entirely different phrase, and I had to stop and hold on to the edge of the console for a moment until it was finished meaning what it meant.

Through the glass, Lucas held up a sign. It was cardboard, cut from the flap of a box from Shenzhen, in his big wobbly capitals:

NIGHT 31!!! (I DIDN'T KNOW WHAT ELSE TO WRITE)
(WELCOME BACK MAN)

Below it, in smaller letters, pressed so hard the marker had torn through: DONNA SAYS CHECK THE STAIRS.

"Line one," said Margo, a minute later, because there is always a line one. "You're on the air."

"Margo. It's Vince."

"Hi, Vince."

"Is he there?"

"He's right here."

There was a pause, and then, from the far end of the line, over the radio and through the phone and back out of the monitor speakers, came a sound like the engine of a CTA bus idling at a red light. It went on for a long time.

"Scarface," said Vince, with great satisfaction, "is sitting on the radio."

"Good evening, Scarface," I said.

The purring did not stop. It got louder. Vince said that was respect, and that he had to go, because Scarface did not like to be held up to the phone for long, but that he would call tomorrow, and the night after, and Margo said she knew, and Vince said *good*, and hung up, and I stood by the window for some time looking at the snow coming down on Milwaukee Avenue and did not say anything at all.

At three o'clock, Margo sent me to the break room for coffee.

I went down the hall. I stopped at the doorway, from habit, the way a dog stops at the edge of a lake, expecting the line of white grains across the old linoleum and the polite invisible wall.

There was a line of salt across the threshold, as there is every night of the winter. Morton's, the girl with the umbrella. Salt is salt.

And in the middle of it, exactly the width of a man, there was a gap.

It had been swept, not scuffed. Three short strokes of a broom. I could see the marks of the bristles in the grains on either side.

Down the hall, at the top of the stairs, I heard a mop go into a bucket, and the squeak of orthopedic shoes, and a woman's voice say, to no one in particular, "Hm."

I walked through the gap. I poured two cups of coffee from the pot that had been sitting on the burner since midnight, and I drank a mouthful of mine standing at the counter, and it was terrible. It tasted like the water a cigarette has been put out in, warmed by a man who resents you. There was a great deal of soap. It was the best thing I had ever tasted, and I had eaten pancakes that morning.

On the counter, beside the coffee maker with the rosary on its handle, there was a fruit basket.

It was very large. It had cellophane and a red bow and a pineapple at the top like a crown. Tucked into the cellophane was a card on heavy cream stock, embossed in gold at the top with PRZYBYLSKI & SONS DISCOUNT CREMATION — *Serving Chicago's Northwest Side Since 1951*. It

was, I realized, one of their sympathy cards. The printed words inside said WITH DEEPEST SYMPATHY IN YOUR TIME OF LOSS. Someone had crossed out SYMPATHY in shaky fountain pen and written above it, CONGRATULATIONS, and crossed out LOSS and written GAIN, and at the bottom, in the same hand:

To the talent. Welcome to the family business. Keep the old copy. — S.P.

I put the card in the inside pocket of my coat, next to a sticker that said HELLO, my name is DENNIS. I carried two cups back down the hall.

She said it at 4:20, during a call about a snowplow.

A man in Mayfair was explaining that the city plow had buried his car for the third time that week, and Margo said, in her flattest voice, "I wish the Streets and Sanitation guys would just—"

I was across the console before she finished. My hand came down flat on the red button that says DUMP in letters worn half away, and her coffee jumped, and through the glass Lucas looked down at his blinking light with an expression of enormous, weary betrayal.

Nothing happened.

Of course nothing happened. The wish was spent. Her soul was already in my keeping, folded small and safe, and there was nothing left in her that any word could buy. She could say *I wish* a hundred times a night for the rest of her life and the only thing it would ever summon was the man in Mayfair saying *hello*?

I looked at my hand on the button. Margo looked at my hand on the button.

"You know that doesn't do anything," she said.

"I know."

"Even before. It never did anything."

"I know," I said, with as much dignity as I could gather.

"It is a habit."

"It's been one day."

"It is a very *strong* habit," I said, and Margo Dunleavy laughed on the air, the low laugh from the hallway the night of Nineveh, and every line on the board lit up at once to ask what was so funny, and she didn't tell a single one of them.

At twenty to seven we went up to the roof.

The snow had stopped. The roof was white and new, with no path worn through it yet, and the old water tank stood up against the gray like it had been put there for scale. Across the street, Stasia's had been open for an hour and forty minutes. The window booth was empty. There was a cup of coffee on the table, steaming, and another across from it.

"She poured two," said Margo. "I haven't even crossed the street yet. She just poured two and walked away."

"Stasia does not ask," I said.

"No," said Margo. "She doesn't have to."

We stood by the tank. Close. Not the bus-stop distance; there was no distance at all. She had her hands in the pockets of her peacoat and her shoulder against my arm, and I could feel her warmth through the good wool, the way she had once felt mine through it like a car hood in January.

In the east, over the towers, the sky was going the color of dishwater.

"It's going to take you," she said.

"Yes."

"Like before. Mid-sentence."

"Very likely."

She was quiet. I listened. I did not need to; I could have heard her from the waiting room by then, I think, if desire carried that far. But I listened anyway, because it is the thing I have done longest, and because there is nothing in five thousand years I have liked listening to more.

She was not afraid. That was the thing. I had stood beside so many mortals at the end of so many nights, and every one of them had been holding their breath. Margo was breathing slowly, in and out, watching the sky. What she wanted was very simple and very loud.

Tomorrow night.

The edge of the sky went white as a page.

"I was going to say," I said, "that I have been thinking about the snow, on the twenty-first, when you stood in it with your tongue out, and I thought—"

"Hold that thought," said Margo.

And for the first time in five thousand years, I did.

I held it all day, under the tube, in the waiting room, beside a photograph of a man crying on a curb. I held it through the hold music and the strings and the girl from somewhere sunny walking past, and I did not mind the waiting at all, because for the first time in my very long life I knew exactly what I was waiting for.

At 2:14, it was there.

Thank you for reading!

Margo and Dennis are on the air every night at WDRY 1490. If you'd like to spend more time in After Dark in Chicago, the next book is Tagged Male: she's scheduled to neuter him Monday, and the full moon is Sunday.

— Tiffany Wayne